Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

David Friesen

Bassist David Friesen has enjoyed a long career as a sideman for such artists as John Handy, Joe Henderson, and Billy Harper. As a leader he has recorded many original compositions that combine technical mastery with spiritual implications.

David was interviewed via Zoom on September 24, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very happy to have bassist and composer David Friesen with me this afternoon. Welcome, and thanks, and congratulations on your career.

DF: Well thank you very much. I have a little white sign on my iPhone now. I can't see you at all. It says this meeting is being recorded.

MR: You can't see me now?

DF: No this little white notice, I just received, that this meeting is being recorded. The account owner can watch this recording if it's stored in the cloud participants, granted permission.

MR: Okay. So I don't know what that means, I mean we're still recording and I think I'm recording you but you just can't see me.

DF: And now I just — it's just I can't see you. There's this little white thing. I've never had this before. It says this meeting is — it's from your end and it's blocking your face so I can't see you.

MR: Wow. Well what's your day like tomorrow or the next day?

DF: I'm available — let me look at my — yeah, —Oh it's okay now. It's okay. I scrolled all the way down and it says "got it." Go ahead.

MR: All right. I'm going to start again and we'll snip out the other stuff with a razor blade. My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and we are from one coast to the next, happy to have David Friesen here with me this afternoon, bassist and composer. Welcome, sir.

DF: It's good to be here. Good to meet you, Monk.

MR: I was going to start off with — I have the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz* and the *All Music Guide to Jazz* and you are mentioned in both of them. And I was going to read an excerpt but then I thought what if you had the opportunity to write your own entry for the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz*? How would you use to describe your music? What would you say succinctly to sort of sum up your philosophy about music?

DF: Well music for me, playing music for me is to show forth the glory of God. Not by my power but by His power, and not for my glory but for His glory. And the concept is jazz. I'm a jazz musician. I'm an improviser. But in terms of music and why I am doing what I am doing, that was it.

MR: Was your faith in place as a child before you became a professional musician?

DF: Well I was raised — it's interesting — my sister and I were raised in a home. My parents were married for I think six years before my mom passed. My dad was a Christian. My mom was Jewish — came from Russia, a Russian Jew. And so I went to Jewish temple in the beginning but then on the way to the Jewish Sunday School my dad would preach Christ to me. And when I got to the Jewish synagogue they didn't want to hear about that. What it did, what it did, it gave me — something happened. They gave me the freedom of choice, where I wasn't going to be manipulated to believe one way or another. Whatever happened, how ever the Lord intervened. Go ahead.

MR: Do you think that that freedom of choice early on like that, with such an important subject, helped you form a way of being as a musician with making significant choices that would suit you?

DF: Yeah. You know I think we're all affected by what happens to us in life you know. Every little detail of how we live, you know, I was going to say imposes its way into our psyche. But that sounds a little negative. Everything we do in life, whether we're shopping for groceries or whatever, inside this flesh is a spirit. And I'm no different now than when I'm playing music. It's the same, it's the same spirit. So whatever I collect in my life, when I'm not playing my instrument, comes out when I am playing my instrument.

MR: You know Maria Schneider said something along those lines. She encouraged her students to not be so one-sided about just music, like live your life. And you have to be a full person in order to create something meaningful.

DF: Yeah. That's right. In my situation when I became a — when I made a commitment to Christianity, to Christ, then there's a Scripture that says, "I know my sheep and my sheep know my voice, and no man can pluck them out of my hand." My life was following the Lord and so I could do choices I made I could make with confidence in my life. It wasn't just half-assed, or, there was, Jesus is called the light of the world. So you know I don't think of my faith as a feeling. When I think of feeling I think of a blind man reaching out feeling his way through life. But Christ is called the light of the world so when the light's turned on I can see where I'm walking. I can see where I'm going.

MR: Nice. I was looking at the list of folks you've played with and I'm going to do a quick "saxophone player" list: John Handy, Sam Rivers, Michael Brecker, Joe Henderson, Johnny Griffin, Stan Getz, Dexter Gordon and on and on. And being a saxophone player,

I'm wondering if these gentlemen asked for different things, or demanded different things from you as a bassist? Do you recall it being different playing with Johnny Griffin as it was for Stan Getz or — how did you adjust?

DF: Well you adjust to the music being played. In other words I don't go on with the concept that I should play this way or that way. My philosophy about this music is this: everything we learn in the practice room, we practice chord scale relationships, technique, all the things we learn there should give us the freedom to be able to take our eyes off ourselves, listen, and respond creatively to what we are hearing. So rather than going — because a lot of times if a leader says, like for instance in my groups I tell them just — I don't tell them do anything. I have really great players and I don't want to quench their personalities so I say — they just listen and respond creatively to what's going on. They make their own decisions, and I have that luxury playing with these great players. I just listened and responded to what I heard. If I was supposed to play a certain way it would quench that spontaneity inside of myself. So I'd be adhering to what they wanted me to do as opposed to what I was hearing in the music and where it was leading me.

MR: Have you ever had a sideman band member who would after a gig say, "Well David, am I doing what you want?"

DF: Yeah. It's funny, when I did the album "Amber Skies" that was exactly what Chick Corea asked me. He said, "David, man, am I playing the music the way you want?" And I told Chick I says, "I picked you because of the way you play. I want you to bring into the music whatever you hear. There's no rules or regulations here, it's just about all listening." Paul Motian on that gig, I didn't even give him music. He says, "Where's my music?" I says, "I don't give drummers music, just listen, Paul."

MR: You know I noticed that in the videos, I've seen some videos of you and the drummer didn't have a stand, and most of the time you did not have a music stand. So my assumption was that most of the music you were playing was yours, was your composition.

DF: It is mine but I do need a stand. I've got to have a map in front of me because you know I think I have something like 700 pieces of music on record or CDs and I can't remember everything, so I always have — and I'm writing music all the time. So no, I need a map up there for myself. Most of the things, the videos I see, I do see myself with a music stand.

MR: Okay. When you say a "map," is that different from when we think of a chart filled with notes and instructions. Is your map —

DF: That — I call it a map, you know. It's the chord changes, it's the tune and the chords to it, yeah.

MR: All right.

DF: Yeah. I just called it a map. I didn't want to confuse you. Sorry.

MR: That's okay. I wanted to see if I could compare a couple of your compositions. If we go way back to 1976 and you recorded the "Duet and Dialogue" I think the entry that I had that I was going to read from the Grove, it had this sentence, "His experimentation with techniques may be heard on "Duet and Dialogue" where he plays with the bow and plucks the strings with both hands." It seemed to me that you had something pretty innovative there, almost like Stanley Jordan when he did his guitar thing. If you compare that with your compositions from "This Light Has No Darkness" do you have a feeling about how your life has changed since then and has it found its way into the compositions?

DF: Well I'm sure it has. I don't think about things like that if I'm understanding your question clearly. I really don't think about things like that. It's important for me to stay in the moment and so I won't spend time — yeah, I don't know if I'm answering your question correctly. I don't consider that or think about that or plan for that. I just —when it's time to feed the dogs I feed the dogs. When it's time — I just don't spend time — my time musically is spent — I've been playing a lot of piano lately and practicing piano. So I'll play piano for a couple of hours each day and I'll run through a lot of heads on the bass so I can play them clearly. A lot of the music I write is difficult and I have to learn how to play it. So I will practice on the bass, playing the heads you know, things like that. But there's a limit. There's almost like a red flag goes off that says David you're spending too much time on this and it's going to lock you into a certain way of playing. Give it some space, just trust. You've got the technique to play it so — things like that. But that's about the only involvement I get in terms of thinking about the music. Actually it all happens on the bandstand, you know that's where the main practicing takes place is on the bandstand in learning to listen and respond creatively to what I hear and a lot of times what I hear and what I should play with what I'm hearing falters somewhat on the bandstand because it takes me in places I've never been before so there's a type of practicing on the bandstand.

MR: If you ask the average —

DF: And it's not right or wrong what I do. It's what I do. Everyone has a different system. Everyone has a different way of relating to the music and it's not right or wrong it's just the way that person — there are many, many different ways of playing this music, going through the obstacle course you know.

MR: That was a bit of ESP right there because I was just going to ask you about right and wrong. The average jazz musician these days will say there is no such thing as a mistake, it's simply how you deal with it. And I wondered if you ever, while you're playing, think

almost separately about what is my audience hearing. Do I want to play in a manner that I'm cognizant of what people in the audience are hearing.

DF: The only time, of course when I'm playing my mind, my ears, my whole soul is, I've trained myself to listen and respond creatively to what I'm hearing. That's my — I have it in my little book I wrote "listening is my life preserver in the ocean of sound, without it I drown." And so I'm continually doing that. The times I do think about the audience is if I have a composition and I play it and now — if there's an audience — I've played where there's been no audience. But this is when there is an audience I can hear how they respond. I listen to how they respond to the piece that's just been played. And I can think, "Oh yeah, they liked this one, uh huh, well I'm going to use this one on the next gig and I'll see how they respond to that." But that's when I'll think about the audience. But I never think about — I don't have time to think about them when I'm — like today I was at the piano playing and I suddenly realized that we were going to be doing the interview so I went and looked — no I'm four minutes late. I get involved with what I'm doing. And I had a film crew come to my house once. They were doing a segment on local television about artists. And they said, "No David, just go ahead and do what you're doing and we'll take care of everything." And I was at the piano writing a new tune and after a while I felt someone tap me on the shoulder and said, "Hello, David." And I looked and I was kind of surprised there were people there but then I remembered, you know. I've trained myself.

MR: I think I might have heard of that. Did that person — I think you told that person, if it was the same video, that you sort of get a message that there's a song waiting for you at the piano. Just go there and — yeah.

DF: Find it. Right? Yeah. Exactly.

MR: I wish someone would tell me to do that.

DF: Oh you play sax — do you play tenor or alto?

MR: I play alto mostly but I also play the piano so usually I write at the piano and see what's —

DF: Yeah, well all the harmony is right there, so. I can call you up and tell you go to the piano if you like.

MR: Just send me a text. Okay we're going to play a little — name this famous memorable bass line. Okay?

DF: Is this something I played?

MR: I'm not going to tell you.

DF: Oh.

MR: Okay we'll start with something easy. [scats]

DF: That's — I don't know. I have no idea.

MR: Okay so when you were, let's see, in your twenties this might have been a pop hit. Anyway, that was "My Girl" by the Temptations. Okay how about this one?

DF: I didn't listen a lot to those kind of things. What did I listen to in my twenties? To Albert Ayler I guess and Coltrane and Miles, and Ravi Shankar. Those were the people I listened to a lot. I didn't listen to Bob Dylan.

MR: Yeah [inaudible] was on the AM radio in 1967. How about [scats]

DF: That's an easy one. That's Paul with Miles.

MR: Paul with Miles, yeah. Okay this one's a struggle for me but I'll give it a try [scats] I told you it would be hard. What I tried to do earlier today —

DF: Interesting:

MR: — was write out your bass line for the song "N-E-V-E-S."

DF: So that's [scats] Yeah. That one I know.

MR: How did that come to fruition? Did it just come in your head or were you just like sort of sitting with your bass messing around?

DF: Yeah sometimes it is, you know I'll take my bass out of the corner of the music room and just play time, no changes. I'll count off a tempo and I'll just play time, no changes. I'm improvising. And this has been a process of how I write music — one way that I wrote music — and I would play time, no changes for about 15, 20 minutes and then I wouldn't listen to it the same day, the next day I would listen to it. You get a little bit more of an objective view that way. And I'd hear a lot of garbage, so I would take out the garbage like I do in my home, we have a trash can, but I'd hear something that I liked and I'd stop the recording, I'd find out what is that. And then I would write a song based on that idea. So that's one way. Sometimes I'm playing and I'll hear myself play a certain idea and I'll follow it through and then another idea may come — like on this tune — play this figure over and over again and then find a line that will work with this, now go to the piano and record it, both parts, because I can hear it a little clearer that way, and all the harmony is right there. So I don't have one method of writing music. There's different things. This one I think I was just playing and heard this line — I never think I'm going to write in an odd time, I want to write a tune in, you know, in seven or five. I just write the music and then when I go to put it down I find sometimes to my dismay — oh wow, I'm going to have to learn how to play this.

MR: It's funny you say that because when I was trying to transcribe the line I was having trouble with where's one. And —

DF: [scats] The seven, you see?

MR: Oh right. I suspected as much but I didn't get very far with it. And at what point do titles —

DF: And by the way it did sound — I was going to say that's something I played, the way you sang it and the line, sounded like something I might have written, so, and I'm not just saying that but that's the truth.

MR: I appreciate that. I wasn't that far off.

DF: No, you did well.

MR: Okay. At what point do titles come to you and attach themselves to songs?

DF: Yeah you know I have a sheet — a sheet on my iPhone under notes and it's funny, the relationship there, a funny pun notes, it is notes, of different titles that come to me and I write them down. And then I'll have a tune and it will fit this title. Sometimes the title and the music comes together at the same time, something I haven't written down. So there's — it's different all the time. It's different. Now "This Light Has No Darkness" this is the new album with the 33-piece chamber orchestra program. This is almost like here's where my music has come to at this point. One or a few of my favorite albums are "Our Man in Jazz" Sonny Rollins on RCA Victor, "Our Man in Jazz" Henry Grimes, with Billy Higgins, Don Cherry and Sonny of course. The album called "Ornette," Scott LaFaro is playing bass on that one, Billy Higgins again. Yeah Ornette's music and Sonny Rollins. So those are some things I'm listening to a lot and you know I play concerts with Sam Rivers and I've played, I was part of the free music scene in Seattle in the '60s. So I played a lot of that music. "This Light Has No Darkness" doesn't resemble that but it's part of the path that brought me to this place of "This Light Has No Darkness" and of course "This Light Has No Darkness" it means just that. This particular light has no darkness or this light is the truth.

MR: Lovely.

DF: Without arguing about religion — because I won't argue about religion. Everyone has a choice to make in their lives and the freedom to do what they would like to do. My dad told me something I've never forgotten, that I haven't really lived up to in my life's path you know I'm 82 years old now, so up to this point, but I've been stronger in the later years. My dad says, "everyone responds to kindness." That's a big one. You know? And as you know jazz is full of good manners, of allowing a person, if they're playing a phrase [scats] you know they start this phrase and I'll hear this and I might have heard something prior to that was going to move in that direction but when I hear this I have to put on the brakes and allow the Mack truck to go and then I can make the right hand turn so to speak. You know you have to be quick to allow individuals to hear what they want to hear and that's where my response has to add to that music. A lot of times, most times by not getting in the way.

MR: Well you just gave me a David Friesen quote, "jazz is full of good manners."

DF: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: I like it a lot. And when you're playing with someone who too often has bad manners I think that person is removed from your phone list, at least in my experience.

DF: Yeah I mean when that happens that means the person is too full of self, is too involved in himself or herself you know. And my attitude about that is this: it might work for someone else, it doesn't work for me, but — and I have played with — mention no names or whether they're famous or not — I have played with some people that are amazing. I mean technique is just outasight and everything, but they don't listen at all, to what's happening. So that's something I can't play with or use in the music that I play. But you know everyone has a way they want to do things. I try to stay clear of any judgments or anything. And also putting people down. I mean like I'm not even putting that person down that doesn't listen, who won't work with what I do. But the way I see it, Monk, is that everyone is trying to do their best. We're all human. You know? We're all trying to I think do our best and to play music we all want to be appreciated. So whatever I can do to help that, you know, I try to do. You know I've been asked what do you think of this player and that player. And most times these players that I'm mentioning have been incredible players you know it's just amazing you know.

MR: Well said. Are you able to turn off the music machine in your mind when you need to?

DF: I don't have a music machine. If I did I'd get it operated on. The music machine in my mind? I've never heard of that before.

MR: Well I worked a long time on that phrase.

DF: The music machine.

MR: I don't know where that came from but I know that I get these things — like we both are dog owners. And I walk my dog twice a day and I get these things going on in my head, like especially if I'm working on an arrangement. So I'm walking the dog down the sidewalk and I've got this stuff and I'd like to stop it I think, and I wonder if that happens to you?

DF: Well you bring back something that I did when I was going to New York. You know from Portland, Oregon to New York City it's almost four days non-stop with another person. Stopping for gas, stopping for food, but not staying overnight. So from Portland to New York — and I've made this trip 26 times in my life. And I remember driving back to New York a few times and I had record dates on Inner City Records. This is in those early —

MR: I remember, Irv Kratka.

DF: Yeah. Exactly. Is he still with us?

MR: I don't believe he is. No. I'm not sure, but I did meet him once.

DF: Anyways I would compose the music in my mind, arrange it, and by the time I got to New York City I had all the music I was going to play and knew how I was going to play

it at that time. That sounds like a contradiction but this was in the early years. Now I don't arrange my music. It's arranged as we play it. I don't go on with any preconceived way of playing it because that would be boring for me, to do it the same way each time. Even the heads can be altered a little bit. That's what I tell the people playing it, just here's the music, I want to hear how you play my music. I don't want to tell you what I want or how to play it. I want you to — you're a great musician, bring to the table your greatness you know, that kind of thing. But at that time I did that, and on the way to New York that's what I would do, and as you said, the music machine in my mind — I didn't think of it as a machine of gears and stuff like that. It was more of a freedom to it than machine. But I hear you.

MR: In this sense of freedom and playing in the moment does what happened 30 seconds ago and what might happen next enter into being in the moment? If you're in the moment and you feel like playing something does it ever occur to you that I've already played that lick four times? Or doesn't it work that way?

DF: I don't know I'm not thinking no self-condemnation when I'm playing. And let me tell you why I can't think that way. This is for me, and once again this isn't right or wrong it's just the way I approach it. Someone might approach it their way and it's right for them. Senior moment. A senior moment.

MR: Yes a senior moment in the moment.

DF: I had something that I wanted to share with you. You can edit this, aren't you?

MR: Yes.

DF: Good. Edit this out. Make the people believe I know what I'm talking about.

MR: Me as well.

DF: No I don't think of that. I don't think that I've played it before. I have to stay in the moment and if I think about that then the music has stopped. You know time goes on. That sound, where is it? It's in the past. Because we're moving through time and that's reflective of the time we're moving through, an example symbolic of the time that we're moving through. That's in the past now. This is how fast we're moving through time and we have clocks that tell us that in seconds, minutes, hours, days, weeks, months, years. So the moment — I'm playing music and if I'm to stop and say I hear me playing, I hear myself playing a lick that I just played, for instance I think that's what you're saying, an idea, that means the music has stopped, the rest of the band can't say oh stop, Friesen is thinking of something. It has to move on. And I've trained myself to do this. Like when I go and pick up my bass with what some people would call "noodling" I've trained myself to immerse in the music a hundred percent of the time. Whenever I touch my instrument I am into the music. I have to differentiate I guess somewhat with practicing an idea, if I'm practicing an idea I'll give it a chance. If I don't get it right away I just forget about it. I

don't keep trying to put a round ball in a square hole. I find ideas that come naturally and fit and work and most of that comes from music that I compose. I mean to play the heads you know. It takes me to really some strange fingering where I'm having to play thumb down in first position on the bass. Whatever it takes. But no, when I'm actually playing I can't do that. I'm just immersed in the moment. The only thing that would get me out of that is if someone with a tray of dishes dropped them right in front of me, and I probably would stop it. That would get me out of it. I've had to do this, Monk, because I never thought of myself as this great player. I don't think about things like that. That's why I wrote that "Listening is my life preserver in the ocean of sound, without it I drown." It's like I'm in Portland, Oregon. I look up on a clear day and I can see the sun. And from this vantage point I can take that sun and place it inside Portland. The metropolis of Portland is big enough to bring the sun. But If I were to take a trip to the sun, the closer I get the larger the sun becomes and the smaller I become. And that's the way it is with music. The closer I get to the core of music, the smaller I become and that listening — I'm hanging on for dear life.

MR: Very interesting David, thank you. Last question, I looked at your calendar on line and you seem to have frequent gigs, working a lot. Do you ever have days where you wish you weren't working and what do you do to sort of get up for that gig? Or maybe it's just —

DF: I've never had that problem. I always look forward to playing. Yeah. I have a family to support. So I had the four kids, my wife and the four kids, and she wasn't working. I was making — I'm telling you man making a living working as a jazz musician is like walking on water. And I was able to do it because of my faith in the Lord. I was able to do it but it's like walking on water. I always enjoyed playing so much I never had that feeling of it being a burden on a particular day to have to go play. So it's something I never really ever played gigs that I didn't want to play. I've turned down some gigs because of the location and you know there've been some places that I knew they weren't going to listen or it wasn't right for me to go into you know. I remember Eddie Henderson called me when Head Hunters were getting ready to play, and he wanted me to play the bass. I says, "I can't do that. I mean I haven't followed that kind of music, I'm just not the right person for that at all." He tried to convince me I was, but I knew I wasn't so I stay in my little small area of where I can play my music and I can impose and have some great musician with that kind of chops to play that music and I'm not going to get in his or her way. That wouldn't be nice.

MR: Well you remind me here at Hamilton College the motto of the college is "know thyself" and it sounds like you do. Well I want to thank you for your time today, this has really been a joy to learn what's going on. I won't call it a music machine but up here.

DF: Are you a professor at the school?

MR: No. I'm not a professor but I have taught saxophone here and I run this jazz oral history project.

DF: Because you have such great questions you know, I mean really well thought out questions you know.

MR: Well you have well thought out answers I have to say.

DF: Different maybe.

MR: Different, yeah. Well thank you for your time and best of luck with your ongoing experiments at the piano and on the bass, and I thank you for your time today.

DF: I always look for melodies. I love melodies. I love melodies.

MR: When I listen to the how do you pronounce the N-E-V-E-S?

DF: If you — backwards it's seven.

MR: So is it "Neves?"

DF: "Neves" I call it "Neves."

MR: "Neves" well I liked it because it has two hooks right away. It has that hooky bass line and when that orchestration comes in with those pizzicato stuff man, that's like oh, it's so ear friendly.

DF: "This Light Has No Darkness" you're talking about, right? That version.

MR: Yes.

DF: Okay. Yeah. Well listen I did not orchestrate that music. I composed all the music, I did some of the arrangements. The orchestration was done by Kyle Gordon, who was one of I think five orchestrators for the Oppenheimer film that won an Academy Award. He's a young — he's not so young — but yeah, everyone is younger than me. My dad always told me, "Son, always have respect for your elders" but I'm finding it more difficult all the time finding anyone older. But anyways, he's a great young orchestrator, a graduate of UNT — University of North Texas, which has a great jazz program as you know. And so he did the orchestrations for that, and he did such a great job.

MR: Wonderful.

DF: Yeah. It's been a pleasure. I appreciate you wanting to interview me. Did we get everything? We got it all done?

MR: Yes, we got it. And I hope that someday you get in my neck of the woods so I can hear you perform live.

DF: Yes. I will definitely let you know when I'm on the — usually I'm flying over you on my way to Europe. I spent many years and a lot of time in New York and it's such a great — the East Coast — it's a great place to be, I wish I could be there more it just doesn't work out right now.

MR: Okay. Thanks a lot.

408 DF: Thank you, Monk.